Two shores

The smoke inside Ascension's stone
Is not the smoke I used to know;
Here, it is cut with candle blow,
The scent of wool and melting snow.

In Matanzas, the incense rose
With roasting coffee, salt, and sea;
A heavy, humid, breathing prayer
That wrapped around the mango tree.

I came here when the year was white,
A stranger to the silent cold,
With Spanish vowels and ledger notes
Of truths the quiet state controlled.

I thought I'd stepped in Limbo's hall,
So pale the sun, so still the air,
Where hymns were sung like secrets kept
And winter was a constant prayer.

But many years have taught my hands
To read the warmth beneath the frost.
To see the liturgy of love
In casseroles for neighbors lost.

The stoic people in the pews,
Though measured in the peace they share,
Hold steady as the maple roots
In quiet, meditative prayer.

The light falls thin through colored glass,
A pale, Ontario spring awake;
I lift the bread, I pour the wine,
The same body for us to break.

My voice is rich with island sun,
Yet anchored in this limestone floor;
A bridge across the ocean wide,
A keeper of an open door.

I pray for those in cardigans,
For Hamilton in gray and green,
And for the island far away,
The crocodile I haven't seen.

Then stepping from the altar rail,
To melt the distance we embrace;
A touch of Cuba's sudden warmth
To light a quiet, northern place.